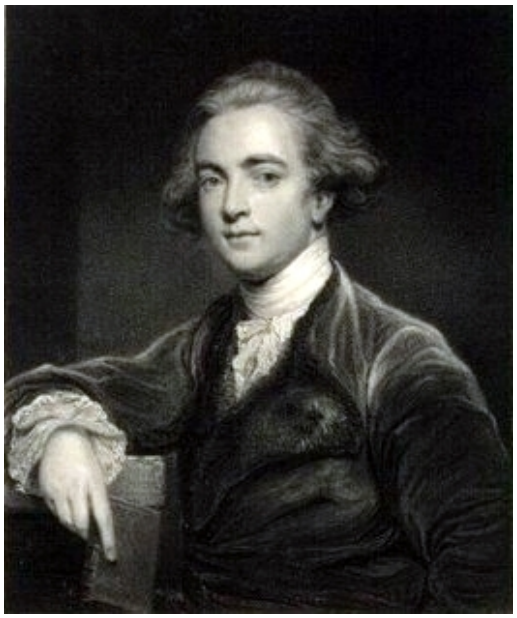


Sir William Jones

The Society worked throughout the 19th century to catalog and analyze the subcontinent's antiquities, and during this time the Taj Mahal became famous throughout first the English-speaking world and then the rest of European and European-influenced societies. By the time of the 1857 Indian Revolt (sometimes called the "Sepoy Rebellion"), the Society had become the "Royal Asiatic Society" and had gained considerable respect in British academic circles. In 1861, when the British Crown had taken over the Indian colonies from the East India Company, they created the first position of Archaeological Surveyor and the Archaeological Survey of India, which was given the power "to prevent injury to and preserve buildings remarkable for their antiquity or for their historical or architectural value."

After Indian Independence, the new Republic kept in place the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), which became the legal guardian of the Taj Mahal and many other sites. Important protections were set up in the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act of 1958 (with major amendments in 2010) and the Antiquities and Art Treasures Act of 1972[41]. The ASI keeps the site open daily year-round, though on Fridays it is only open to Muslim worshipers at the on-site mosque.[42]

Today, the Taj is primarily experienced as a tourist attraction, and it brings in over 2 million domestic and over 400,000 foreign visitors a year. It is the most